FESTIVAL

Home-made Treats

The **Goa Open Arts Festival** is for and by the local community

India's smallest state has a multicultural heritage and a vibrant arts and culture scene that doesn't disappear between March and October. Goa has, for a while now, been a magnet for creative people who have chosen to do more than buy a getaway house in a gated colony with Delhi-Mumbai-Bengaluru neighbours. There is, in other words, more to the Goa arts scene than the Serendipity Arts Festival, as magnificent and tourist-attracting as that endeavour is.

The much smaller Goa Open Arts Festival is determinedly local, a platform for the state's residents, those who claim roots going back generations as well as those who have transplanted themselves more recently.

A conversation between two members of the latter demographic, photographer and photo curator Prashant Panjiar and artist and designer Gopika Chowfla, both looking for ways to connect more deeply with their adopted home, led, in 2019, to the founding of the Goa Open Arts (GOA) with Chowfla's daughter, curator and arts manager Sitara Chowfla, artist Diptej Vernekar and designer and design entrepreneur Gurpreet Sidhu joining in. In 2020, on Valentine's Day, they launched the first edition. It was funded by a few corporate sponsors and private individuals, and art sales.

GOA OPEN ARTS FESTIVAL
Feb. 23-28, Old GMC complex, Panaji, Goa
goaopenarts.com

The festival is not meant to rival Serendipity, which, the older Chowfla says, is "already doing a stellar job of bringing art from around the world to Goa". Instead, GOA was about "giving oxygen to talent that is based in Goa, which makes for continuity and long-term engagements with the artists".

Soon after, Goa, and the world, went into various stages of lockdown. With the future uncertain, the team used the money from their small corpus to launch their Catalyst grants, to help Goa-based artists continue their practice; these have become an annual feature, joined, in 2021, by Engage grants to support projects that benefit the community.

But now the festival is back and will open later this month. The funding model remains the same, and the scale stays modest, but the festival is now going beyond the visual arts, and the core team has expanded to include curators for music (Aviv Pereira), poetry (Rochelle D'Silva), film (Sachin Chatte) and food (Insia Lacewalla), to ensure a wider selection of artists.

As with the earlier edition, the festival issued an open call to ensure that creative people unknown to them could apply. The younger Chowfla says the big learning from 2020 was to stay artists-first: "We wanted to ensure that the artists we work with are represented in the most genuine manner and that they are truly part of the festival." ■

–Peter Griffin





PICTURE OF HAPPINESS
Organisers of the Goa Open Arts Festival (above); Aviv Pereira, music curator for the festival